

obvious reasons, which we cannot print.

And: "Others may get addicted to interacting with them just as many Internet users get hooked to the cyberworld." So a *Charter* to prevent robo-addiction?

We're getting a surreal feeling of dreaminess, as though all this isn't really happening, as though sense and nonsense are getting inextricably interwoven.

"As if the machines were their wives," indeed.

RETHINKING EDUCATION

Games Vs. Books

The latest gaming-related news story doing the rounds is about more video games and fewer books in schools. It's a proposal that's being actively investigated.

We (at least, those in developed countries) live in a digital world, so why should education be so "analogue"—as in old-school? The specific point is, people need to rethink what the best means of delivering education is.

FatBeing Gets a Phoren Trip

"Bugger Nimish," everyone's fuming. Poor chap—all he did was get a ticket to Krautenland, aka Germany, for CeBIT 2007. Even as this is being written, Shady (Samir) and Michael have a glazed look of unadulterated hatred in their eyes, thinking of all the stuff Nimish gets to ogle at and feel and touch. And Ram is seething thinking of the Fräulein Nimish is currently pawing. Poor chap again—when he mails us, he's actually always talking about the blisters on his feet from walking through all the aisles there. Yeah right, we feel sorry!

Raaabo got a few stitches in his arm just the day after Ram warned him of the dangers of bike-riding in India. Naturally, Raaabo's now working from home—but typing with one hand means he isn't

submitting much work.

There's even more other news: three young men have joined our team—Rossi, Asfaq, and Sumedh. We're hoping The Vandal (Michael) won't beat them all up for silly reasons. (He has that irritating habit, and is currently under medication for it.) Asfaq is relatively safe, since he's not in the Test Centre. (Ed told him he could go to CeBIT next year, that's why he's joined us.)

And so, we're (not) waiting for Nimish to return, laden with pics of him with Fräuleins and cars and gizmos. We're thinking of getting Vandal to beat him up—just a little, mind you, no more than one limb—when FatBeing (Nimish) whips out his photo album. Asfaq will probably quit when he sees what he's in for, next year.

DIGIT DIARY

Games can be effective; the question is, how effective, and what kinds of games.

"We've organised our schools using methods from the Middle Ages," said David Shaffer of the University of Wisconsin-Madison, and author of *How Computer Games Help Children Learn*. "The trend toward administering more standardised tests does not prepare children for a digital future."

Of course, no-one is talking about *Doom* and such in classrooms. They're talking about new-gen infotainment games. In a game designed by an Indiana University associate professor, players assume the role of investigators looking to find why fish are dying in a park. Theories are offered, such as excessive logging, and players share data and compare

hypotheses. Does that sound interesting enough? It probably depends on how the game is executed, including such things as the visual feel.

The idea behind the exercise—research into which millions of dollars are being poured—is that games are engaging, so students will play them. Like they'd play *Doom*. Can this new crop of educational games hold as much interest? ■

Blog WATCH

Chris Pirillo's rant on Vista: M\$ has failed to provide a smooth transition from XP. And Orkut is co-operating with the Mumbai police!

Xeni Jardin

(www.boingboing.net/2007/03/13/india_googles_orkut_.html)

India: Google's Orkut helps cops censor?

The Indian Express and other regional media are reporting that Google's social networking service Orkut will cooperate with the Mumbai Police to share IP addresses of users who post "objectionable content" on Orkut. If reports are to be believed, the police need only to email a complaint to Orkut, and Orkut will send back the personally identifying data. The police are said to be targeting a number of "problematic" Orkut posts, including items that criticize various public figures in India, others that glorify Indian mobsters, and "anti-Indian words."

Chris Pirillo

(<http://chris.pirillo.com/2007/03/09/windows-vista-help/>)

Windows Vista Help

It's not about the software anymore—it's about the people who are using the software, and despite all your R&D—these are the very same people you've effectively abandoned by not providing a smooth transition between XP and Vista. You're spending HOW MUCH MONEY on ADVERTISING an OPERATING SYSTEM that PEOPLE ARE HAVING MAJOR ISSUES WITH. Why

NOT spend a FRACTION of that BUDGET on making SOME KIND OF SOLUTION AVAILABLE. Convenient? No. Affordable? Probably not. But who are you serving if you're not serving your customers? ...Don't tell me you can't do it. Microsoft *CAN* do anything.

Tony Hawk

(<http://thomashawk.com/2007/03/how-to-turn-microsoft-around.html>)

How to turn Microsoft around

Microsoft continues to lose market share in search to Google. What is more surprising to me though is what seems like an almost daily slate of negative news on Microsoft. Yesterday I noted that influential analyst Michael Gartenberg was leaving Microsoft as an "enthusiastic evangelist" after less than a month, also this week you had another "enthusiastic analyst" Stephanie Quilao leaving her post after 9 1/2 weeks...

...Now the numbers are not necessarily going to reflect this yet, but when your key influencers, bloggers, journalists, etc. begin abandoning Windows and moving to the Mac it's like a wave and over time this wave can actually threaten Microsoft's monopoly on the operating system. Look for Apple's numbers to continue advancing here in the months ahead. So the question becomes how should Microsoft turn this around?...